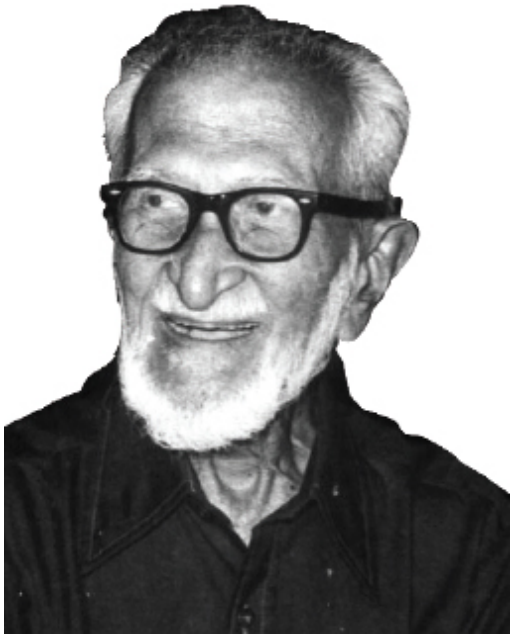


Finding a passion

Born into a well-off family in Bombay, Salim Ali and his siblings often went hunting when they were young, and shot down birds using their air rifles. When he was about ten, Ali bagged an unusual-looking sparrow with a yellow patch on its throat. Intrigued, he took the bird to the head of the Bombay Natural History Society (BNHS), WS Millard, to be identified. This was Ali's first encounter with the world of ornithology. It would spark a lifelong passion for observing and studying birds, which in turn led to Ali almost single-handedly transforming ornithology and conservation in India.

The BNHS was founded in 1883 and remains one of India's largest scientific organizations focused on wildlife research and conservation. Ali served as an honorary secretary and was associated with the organization for most of his life.